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AFRICAN DANCE: THE CONTINUITY OF CHANGE

by Judith Lynne Hanna¹

African dance has, in the past, sent some admiring Western poets and artists into ecstasy and many Christian missionaries and other colonialists into a state of horror. "The quintessential aesthetic form" or "the expression of moral turpitude," respectively, were common verdicts. And frequently, early European observers of African behavior did not consider African dance to be dance, for it was not the familiar classical ballet or foot-tapping folk dance of their home countries. Perceptions and evaluations are now more balanced. We have first-hand reports about African dance by African and other scholars, an extensive survey of old and new literature relevant to African dance, an increasing number of African dance films, and African dance companies that have performed around the world.²

What is African Dance?

Africa has about 1000 different languages and probably as many dance patterns. Dance styles vary enormously and so do definitions of dance. For example, among the Ibo, Akan, Efik, Azande, and Kamba, dance involves vocal and instrumental music, including the drum, whereas among the Zulu, Matabele, Shi, Ngoni, Turkana, and Wanyaturu, drums are not used, and sometimes the users of drums are despised.³ In the United States and other non-African countries, conceptions of dance also vary. Nevertheless, I believe that it is possible to develop a general definition: *dance* is composed of purposefully, intentionally, rhythmical, and culturally patterned sequences of nonverbal body movements and gestures which are not ordinary motor activities, the motion having inherent value.⁴ It is human behavior. And in Africa, dance has a significance far greater than in most Western countries. It is *physical* behavior; the human body as the instrument of dance releases energy through muscular responses to stimuli. It is *artistic* behavior, each group having its own aesthetic criteria. Dance is thus meaningful in terms of a performer's or spectator's sensory indulgence as he responds within a range from dissatisfaction to euphoria and with the expectation that in a particular dance style the various elements of dance — space, rhythm, dynamics — will be recognizable. Until recently African dance was rarely art for its own sake. Rather it was utilitarian — "art" for life's sake.

African dance is *cultural* behavior, determined by the values, attitudes, and beliefs of a people. The relationship between dance and

other aspects of culture is reciprocal; dance often contributes to the continuity and change. Dance is *social* behavior reflecting relationships among individuals in groups and among groups themselves in a society. It is *psychological* behavior, in the sense of being an emotional experience which affects the quality of and adjustment to an individual's self existence and group life. As *economic* behavior, African dance may be performed for a fee to supplement or sustain one's livelihood, and sometimes to enhance one's occupational skills or values. As *political* behavior, the dance may be a forum for articulating political attitudes and values and an arena for leadership training which carries over to positions in other spheres of life.

Finally, dance in Africa is *communicative* behavior in that movements can form a para- or quasi-language, sometimes more effective than verbal language. Indeed, dance is often a multimedia communication: performers moving in time and space are seen, sounds of physical movements are heard, odors produced by physical exertion are smelled, kinesthetic activity or empathy is felt, as is the touch of body to body, body part, and performing area. African dance is thus significant because it has powerful communication potential as it refers to things outside itself, evoking associations about ideas, feelings, and physical things. It is within this sense of meaning that dance appears to contribute to the continuity of essential attributes in African societies.⁵

Forces of Change

African dance tenaciously persists as a vital force in spite of attempts to destroy or transform it.⁶ Imperial rule and the post-independence nation-states have had profound impacts upon dance (as well as virtually all other aspects of old Africa). Because of the intimate relationship between aboriginal dance and religion, the imposed religions destroyed the *raison d'être* of much dance. Christian missionaries, supported by European administrators who viewed African dance as licentious, bestial display within the "civilized" Victorian standards of the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, were probably most responsible for the modification, suppression, or disappearance of traditional dancing. It was the manifestation of "savage heathenism" and thus antagonistic to the "true faith." Unfortunately, many outsiders failed to recognize that most African dances had universal themes and origins comparable to European folk dances. Nor did they realize that dances involving much pelvic movement or upper torso shimmying could be a glorification of fertility related to dire needs: abundant harvests in the face of threatening, uncontrollable natural elements and a large family necessary for work, protection, old age security, and a manpower pool capable of replacing the many victims of infant mortality, war, disease, and other vagaries of nature. European colonialists also banned African dances for their own convenience: the dancers' dynamic musical accompani-

ment and the spectators' enthusiastic shouts of joy sometimes disturbed the sleep or work of Europeans, or the dance distracted the attention of working Africans who might be further enticed away from their European controlled jobs to join the dances.

African dances were also repressed by the process of providing Western education to Africans to spread the gospel, fill the colonialists' need for administrative and economic manpower, and meet Africans' desires for material advancement and improved status in the new society. Many children were removed from their home environments (most African secondary schools were boarding because qualified students were widely dispersed and study facilities were inadequate in the home) at the time when they could learn dances effortlessly, gain skill, and become sufficiently steeped in traditional culture to be an important vehicle for its transmission. And the dance was affected by Africans' exposure to alien experiences and societies through their service in both world wars.

With independence, some African leaders have used dance for what they believe to be the national interest, and sometimes their personal political purposes.⁷ This may mean encouraging the renaissance of African dance in its pre-European forms as Africans question the status which Europeans ascribed to African cultures, undergo a sociocultural reappraisal, and seek anew their traditions; there is even some importing of cultural elements which had died at home but survived abroad. Or political leaders may promote or permit African dances with denotative or connotative meanings that reinforce or at least do not conflict with programs for modernity. Sometimes dances are deliberately used instrumentally for political party communications, while at other times they are banned for having antigovernment messages. A number of nations, including Cameroon, Dahomey, Ethiopia, Ghana, Guinea, Ivory Coast, Mali, Nigeria, Senegal, Sierra Leone, Uganda, Zaire, and Zambia, send their own national dance companies or *ad hoc* groups abroad to project the national image and cultural identity.

Over the course of time, the structure and style of dance have evolved as the result of the perception of supernatural revelation, mythical precedence, individual or special group initiative, and (especially) contacts with other peoples. African dance has always been a kaleidoscopic phenomenon as have the cultures of which it is part. But the vitality of dance persists in most areas, and it seems to contribute to some of society's key needs — maintaining cultural patterns, managing tensions, attaining goals, adapting to the environment, and integrating members of the community.⁸

Significance of African Dance

- (1) Dance is used to teach and reinforce cultural patterns. For the Chaga children the *shiganu* dances intensify the oral instructions concerning tribal mores.⁹ Many groups have dances which ridicule

in gesture, movement, song, and music those guilty of offensive behavior. The dancers may be in masquerade or their bodies temporarily possessed by a supernatural entity, and thus they can perform with freedom from "libel" or other retribution. Family obligations are one of the most frequently communicated themes in African dance. Among the Ubakala and other groups, the birth of a child is celebrated, and men and women who have many children are praised. Sexual lore and social responsibility are communicated in the Bavenda *domba* (python dance) which recurs throughout the premarital initiation school for boys and girls.¹⁰ Obligations of parents to each other and to their children are explicit in dance song phrases such as the Ubakala "Whether or not I know how to behave, exercise patience and live with me" or the Mossi lyric "My husband keep me well. . . a woman ages as quickly as okra."¹¹

Religious traditions, achievement and status values, and economic patterns are communicated through the dance. The Dogon dance team and masked society dancing patterns depict the group's cosmology, its conception of the whole world with its progress and order. The mask or woven head allows broad representation (of all people, ages, animals, spirits, activities, and things) and order exists in dancing, i.e., each mask has certain patterns, rhythms, and procedural routines.¹² In some areas people dance to honor those in higher positions, in others such as Onitsha, the king is required to dance before his people at the annual yam feast to retain his position of honor.¹³ Many African peoples have dances which mime traditional occupational behavior important to the local economy. The dances serve as media to give work instruction and provide practice in the various required movements, strengthen muscles used in the work, and develop endurance. Dancing itself may be an occupation, with participants recruited through family tradition or open competition in talent and individuality.

- (2) African dances help to control the tensions of individuals and groups. Some dances prepare an individual for a threatening experience by rehearsing it until its potential destructive impact becomes manageable. Among the Dogon, masked dances occur at the time of death to help the community cope with the psychological distress over a death and the spiritual fear of the dead. Man thus restores order to the disordered world in a like-equals-reality conception, for order exists in the dancing with its specific symbolism and patterns.¹⁴ Ubakala girls dance upper torso shimmy movements which emphasize their physical maturity, and they call their dances by themes which reflect hopes and anxieties related to marrying, leaving one's familiar home to live with the husband's kin, and bearing children. The dance "Pregnant Child" refers to a small

girl's fear that when she marries she may not become pregnant or deliver successfully.

Sometimes African dances are cathartic, i.e., they provide a mechanism—a safety-valve—for expressing a dangerous impulse in a comparatively harmless way. The Irigwe traditionally marry several spouses from different tribal areas and the women shift residence among husbands several times during their lifetime. Possession in dance apparently helps to relieve the tensions stemming from the women's repeated separations from loved ones. During the dance the women often cry, speak in tongues, and move frenetically, giving vent without castigation to their repressed feelings.¹⁵ Dance is frequently a legitimate setting for otherwise prohibited or inappropriate "promiscuity," criticism, and joking. The Nigerian psychiatrist Dr. T. Lambo argues that essential psychological functions of dance are prevention of depression and discharge of other psychic stresses.¹⁶

- (3) African dance often makes a contribution to the attainment of societal goals. Dance is used to motivate men to participate in battle and other work activities. As an accompaniment to work or interspersed with it, dance stimulates the individual's involvement, provides distractions, and generally makes work less a chore. For example, a group of Nupe women combine dance with the pounding of earthen hut floors and entry platforms as they press closely against each other in concentric circles. Bending low over the floor they beat the ground, unfold their bodies lifting both hands in the air and dance towards the center and back bending once again to beat the floor with the heavy wooden flail held in the right hand.¹⁷
- (4) Dance is involved in adaptation, providing goods and services from the environment to the society, especially from the supernatural environment, including the ancestors, spirits, and gods. Dance is a form of worship in many African societies; worship often goes beyond prayer, quiet and solemn contemplation, to include bodily action as well.¹⁸ At regularly scheduled, crisis, or spontaneous times, dances may be part of rituals through which deities, ancestors, and other natural entities are revered and receive supplications for their beneficence. The dance is sometimes considered the medium for conducting supernatural beneficence. Thus Kiganda parents of twins performed dances in the gardens of friends so that the dance could transmit human fertility to vegetation.¹⁹ Dances in which individuals become possessed are ways in which men can meet their tutelary spirits when either wishes to communicate. Possession dance is a crucial element of the traditional Ga new year ritual requesting supernatural help for the well being of the tribe in

the coming twelve months. Such needs as rain, fish, crops, and health are presented to the god who then, through the possessee, delivers messages prophetic of the coming year's events and how to cope with them. Similarly, masked dancers enlist supernatural support. The Tyi Wara masked dance of the Bamana was performed to invoke the blessings of the god of agriculture on man's difficult farming effort.²⁰

- (5) African dance contributes to the integration of society. It is frequently part of rites inducting young people or strangers into adult society. It insures courtship opportunities and provides motivation for young men and women as a prelude to creating a nuclear family. Lotuka girls take their dancing seriously for they know that prospective husbands are watching.²¹ The Kaka's *tadjo* dance is designed to bring together the youth for acquaintance and possible marriage.²² Among some groups, affection for a member of the opposite sex is shown through specific dance movements performed for and near the chosen person.

Feelings of solidarity often stem from group dancing. Married Ubakala women moving together in a circular spatial pattern, symbolic of unity, sing the couplet of a popular dance-song: "Ubakala, we are coming, Ebere-e, Ebere-e, we are coming/Peace be with you as we come together." For the Kung Bushmen the dance is a socially unifying factor for all the people come together to participate, the men often dancing with their babies on their shoulders.²³

Every society has divisions. Dance often contributed to the consciousness of different statuses and the duties and responsibilities that go with them, thus affecting the bonds of social organization. For the Dahomean it is said that the higher a man advances in the social scale the more restrained his dancing becomes. The steps of the chief's dance are deliberate with controlled pauses and none of the pirouettes, leaps, or sharp turns that mark the dancing of those holding inferior rank.²⁴

Continuity of Significance in New Contexts

Change has continually buffeted and affected African dance. Today, in an age of rapid urbanization, technological progress, and the spread of mass media, change has accelerated its pace and its impact upon all individuals. (Alvin Toffler illustrates this process in the United States in his best seller *Future Shock*.²⁵) Africa has been profoundly touched by this phenomenon, although the degree of impact varies widely across the continent. The basic contributions African dance makes to society continue however, as dance adapts to new desires and behaviors, its forms modified, its essential stylistic elements persisting. Modifications in dance occur even in those villages which have resisted change and

where substantive culture change has been slight. Sacred dances are now often held at different times than they used to be, for example, on Western or national holidays so that some of the key participants who work or attend schools in towns can attend.

Traditional dances are perpetuated outside their original contexts; the fusion of old and new is a recurring phenomenon. People continue to be *socialized* to old and new values through African dance which is being introduced into schools and churches. In rural and urban areas it celebrates Christian church marriages, installations of contemporary government representatives, dedications of modern schools and hospitals, and achievements of Western professional accreditation. War dances no longer appropriate for battle preparation continue to recount history and to proclaim national identity—now that of heterogeneous peoples within new boundaries. For example, traditionally, when the Kikuyu wished to proclaim a new government, they held war dances as the medium to announce the laws and regulations of the new constitution.²⁶ Needless to say, when Kenyatta, a Kikuyu, became the first president of Kenya, the war dances of all ethnic groups were called for throughout the country, and they continue to celebrate independence.

As is the case world-wide, in times of great transience, solace and *tension control* are often sought in traditional dances held in both rural and urban areas. For illiterate migrants who regularly dance in urban and suburban areas during their nonworking hours, traditional dance provides a sense of belonging, warmth, and affirmation of their clan or ethnic identity, and a relief from the tensions of the alien, heterogeneous, sometimes hostile urban milieu often far distant from their homes.

Topical dance forms and themes weave continuous threads through the history of many cultures. There is no paradox between externally stimulated forms with indigenous impulses and traditions; foreign cultural elements are rarely passively accepted in dance. Thus African dance is used to introduce change. This is illustrated in the public display of heterosexual physical contact, a potentially threatening experience for a people with traditional mores forbidding it. Through their traditional dance-play form, young Ubakala girls rehearse this behavior until its possible stressful impact becomes manageable; they form pairs and caress each other in satiric exaggeration of the Western ballroom dance position in which a man and woman dance clasped together in public.

Dance still makes a contribution to the *attainment of societal goals*. It is still sometimes a component of work projects, now serving as pleasurable distraction from, and motivation to, the completion of mining tasks and other technological projects. Traditional African dance has been modified through the fusion of different ethnic dance forms and harnessed as a medium to promote democratic socialism and modernization in Tanzania.²⁷ Dance continues to facilitate *adaptation* to the supernatural

environment. Traditional dancing has been introduced into Christian churches as a part of prayer. Many church leaders have come to realize that drawing upon the deeply rooted traditional forms with which the people grew up, facilitates communication. (This tendency is similar to that occurring in the United States: Jesus rocks! i.e., there is a new kind of rock music and dance appearing in many churches as part of an effort to reach young people.) African dance may even manifest itself in spite of Christian religious doctrine interpreted as forbidding it. I saw a vivid example of this during an Apostolic church service held in a small village 20 miles from Ilesha, Nigeria. The physical body postures, gestures, and movements, including the handclapping of the congregation, strongly resembled the area's traditional Yoruba dancing I observed. African dance is frequently performed during celebrations as a form of blessing and thanks, individuals within a heterogeneous religious grouping relating to their own relevant deities.

African dance continues to contribute to the *integration* of society. In contemporary times it still insures courtship opportunities for the young. Many compete within their schools and between schools or at the village level with the best groups taking part in festivals, perhaps at the regional or even national level as in Nigeria and Uganda. In Uganda, the performance of traditional dance was considered by the Commander of the Army and Air Force to be a medium for members of diverse tribes, civilians and soldiers, educated and illiterate to get to know each other and forge a national identity and pride. And the *chiwoda* dance competitions in Malawi promote cohesion — the stronger the desire to win, the greater the village unity.²⁸

Of course, in some areas of black Africa traditional dance is no longer as significant as it was. Change may make African dance more “artistic,” profane, and professional, divorced from important aspects of individual and collective life. This happens in performing for tourists, promoting cultural festivals and competitions, developing national dance companies, and creating choreography based on traditional dance for new theatrical productions. However, African dance, with its roots in the cultural, social, psychological, economic, and political life of a people, intermeshed with facets of life from birth to death, generally continues to be significant, reflecting changes and contributing to them, meeting old and new needs, and changing as it always has.

FOOTNOTES

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